

ON THE JOB :There are 10 million street children in India



GRADUATE and postgraduate beggars are increasing **MORE** able-bodied beggars than disabled **Rs 25,000** average bank balance of beggars in Kolkata

poverty. No wonder, 66 per cent beggars are able-bodied. "Begging as a livelihood wins over casual labour," says Tandon. "For 96 per cent, the average daily income is Rs 80, more than what daily-wage earners can make." Spending patterns are also telling: 27 per cent beggars spend Rs 50-Rs 100 a day.

Mumbai is the Mecca of beggars. According to the Maharashtra Government, they are worth Rs 180 crore a year, with daily income ranging between Rs 20-Rs 80. Three of the richest beggars—Haji, Massu and Bharat Jain—allegedly have assets ranging from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 70 lakh. They earn up to Rs 200 a day and live with families where no one else begs. Jain's family deals in school stationery, Massu's sons are hawkers and Haji's family earns a steady income

from zari embroidery work. They beg, despite family pressure to give it up. When the Manav Sena Trust of Mumbai approached 98 beggars with jobs, all of them turned down the offers as being less remunerative.

Almost every survey profiles beggars as a largely contented lot, unwilling to take up "honest labour". Nearly 26 per cent in the DSSW survey claimed they were "happy". "Do you face any problems while begging?" asked the survey team. A surprising 81 per cent said "No", with only 15 per cent mentioning "humiliation" from the public and police. A survey done in 2004 by the Social Development Centre of Mumbai revealed similar attitude. "The majority latch on to begging as a profitable and viable profession," says Vijay M. Karande, the secretary.

Psychiatrists, however, sketch a different portrait. A study published in

the *International Journal of Psychosocial Rehabilitation* by Dr Yogesh Thakker reveals that 39 per cent of the 49 beggars surveyed in Gujarat's Baroda district by a group of medicos suffer from one or other psychiatric illness. Nearly 74 per cent of them had a history of addiction, psychiatric illness in the family and poor attitude of family members towards them. Over 68 per cent admitted to feeling of shame and losing self-esteem, 25 per cent to guilt, 4 per cent to suicidal tendencies, 8 per cent to anti-social activities.

Reports of wealthy beggars and maiming to maximise gains—media favourites—have distorted the lens through which the nation looks at its underclass, feel people who work among them. "Reports that the begging community is ruled by a gangland which rakes in financial gains is not